

Agency and Public Action

Issue

Climate change and economic development projects have major impacts on the St. Lawrence River and on coastal communities. Some individuals and groups choose to influence public policies in order to protect the ecosystems of the St. Lawrence and to contribute to the socio-ecological transition. In this context, it is important to better understand the sense of empowerment and the capacities for action of these people, sometimes referred to as *policy entrepreneurs*, who devote themselves to changing policies by proposing new ideas and sociopolitical alternatives.

Research Objective and Questions

The objective of this research is to shed light on the factors that support, or hinder, the sociopolitical actions of individuals or groups considered to be change agents in public policy within the context of socially sensitive issues related to the St. Lawrence. To do so, we identify three areas of inquiry focusing on the sense of empowerment, the actions undertaken, and the roles, capacities, and incapacities:

- How do change agents describe their feelings about the issue that concerns them and about their actions or inaction?
- What actions do they carry out, and what reasons do they give to explain these actions?
- What roles, capacities, and incapacities do they attribute to themselves in influencing (or not) change?

Methodology

In this multiple case study, four socially sensitive issues surrounding the St. Lawrence serve as objects of investigation:

- Mobilizations against offshore oil and gas exploration and extraction projects (Old Harry)
- The transformation of fishing activities toward more equitable, proximity-based practices (Tourelle)
- Conflicts over the uses and perceptions of space related to port activities (Contrecoeur)
- Recognition of the St. Lawrence River as a legal person

Each case illustrates a controversial public policy process in which change agents, particularly policy entrepreneurs, seize windows of opportunity to reframe problems, keep their concerns on the political agenda, and propose solutions or social innovations aimed at, for example, preventing the destruction of sensitive ecosystems, promoting more equitable management of marine resources, demanding environmental justice, or advocating for the recognition of the St. Lawrence's inestimable ecological and cultural value. For each case, individuals considered to be change agents are selected and invited to participate in semi-structured interviews. The selection ensures a diversity of positions and power relations, including: community representatives, NGOs, elected officials, scientists, public servants, concerned citizens, fishers, and citizen groups.

TEAM

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Relevance of the Study

Scientific Relevance

- Improve understanding of how change agents perceive their own sense of empowerment in relation to the socio-ecological issues that concern them.
- Highlight the capacities and incapacities they attribute to themselves, as well as the resources they mobilize.
- Draw connections between the various theoretical concepts explored, particularly *policy entrepreneurship*.
- Clarify the determinants and competencies that support, or undermine, the sociopolitical actions of individuals working toward the socio-ecological transition.

Educational Relevance

- Support the development of pedagogical tools aimed at strengthening the sense of empowerment of individuals (including young people), as well as communities.
- Highlight examples of people who undertake sociopolitical action and the strategies they use to influence public policies.
- Support the development of young people's civic capacities for action in the context of climate change education that is critical, political, and transformative.

Sociopolitical Relevance

- Identify barriers that hinder the ability of change agents to take action.
- Shed light on the capacities, resources, and levers they mobilize, to inform reflection on mechanisms that could facilitate access to or the development of these resources.
- Improve understanding of how public problems are constructed and the dynamics of change in public policies.
- Inspire hope among people who wish to influence public policies and help build mechanisms of solidarity essential to the societal and environmental changes required in the current climate crisis.

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Territories of study for analyzing the agency of policy entrepreneurs.

